Everything Was Already Alive

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Title Page

EVERYTHING WAS ALREADY ALIVE

An original feature screenplay

Philosophical drama · Poetic realism · Slow cinema

A note before reading

No one in this film has a name. They are known by what they do, or by what they are to the young man at its centre. The city is never named either. It is a coastal city, old in places, with buses, narrow upper rooms, a market, a long seafront.

The people

- **THE PROTAGONIST** (early 20s). Quiet, watchful, polite in a way that keeps people at arm's length. Funny when he forgets himself. Speaks in short sentences and often answers a question with a question.
- **THE MOTHER** (50s). Works long shifts at a pharmacy counter. Practical, tired, affectionate in actions rather than words. Took photographs once, before he was born. Never talks about it.
- **THE FRIEND** (early 20s). Known the protagonist since school. Loud, warm, restless. Has just got a job in another city and is trying to say goodbye to someone who won't stand still long enough to hear it.
- **THE PAINTER** (70s). Lives alone in a narrow house full of canvases. Dry, stubborn, occasionally petty, very funny without trying. Missed the one chance he had, forty years ago, and has opinions about everyone who didn't.
- **THE MUSICIAN** (40s). Practises guitar in a room above a hardware shop. Teaches children on weekends to pay rent. Calm on the surface, short-tempered with himself. Hums when he's thinking.
- **THE DANCER** (mid-20s). Rehearses alone in a rented community hall in the early afternoons. Works night shifts at a call centre. Has a knee that sometimes refuses. Laughs easily, especially at herself.

- **THE FLORIST** (60s). Opens her shop before sunrise. Brisk, unsentimental, rude to customers she likes.
- **THE BUS DRIVER** (late 50s). Has driven the same route for twenty-six years. Two years from retirement and doesn't know what he'll do with his hands.
- **THE OLD COUPLE** (80s). Sit on the same bench by the sea every afternoon. Married fifty-one years. Rarely speak. Argue about the crossword.
- **THE YOUNG PARENT** (late 20s). A father who carries his sleeping daughter home from the night bus.
- **THE VENDOR** (40s). Sells fruit from a handcart near the market. Counts losses out loud.
- **THE WIDOW** (60s). Buys the same flowers every Thursday. Doesn't say why.

How it should look and sound

- Early scenes frame the protagonist behind glass, in doorways, in reflections, at a distance. Muted colours, cool daylight.
- As the project grows, his footage becomes controlled: symmetrical, tripod-locked, perfectly lit. The film around him stays loose.
- As he changes, the camera relaxes. Longer takes, warmer and more varied natural colour. The world itself does not change. Only how it is held.
- Two textures of image: the film's own camera, and the protagonist's footage (marked **CAMCORDER FOOTAGE** or **ON LAPTOP SCREEN**), which is smaller, grainier, sometimes tilted.
- Sound carries the film: room tone, traffic, wind, the sea, brush on canvas, strings, breathing, a dripping tap in the protagonist's flat. Music only when someone in the scene is making it.

Recurring motifs

- A rectangle of sunlight that crosses the protagonist's bedroom wall every afternoon.
- A patch of blue on an unfinished canvas.
- A melody that is never played the same way twice.
- A curtain moving in an empty room.
- People trying to photograph the sky.

Act One — The Window

FADE IN:

1. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — AFTERNOON

A bare wall. Faded paint, a nail with nothing hanging from it.

A rectangle of sunlight lies on the wall. We hold on it. Slowly, almost imperceptibly, it slides to the right.

The sounds of a building in the afternoon: a pressure cooker somewhere below, a television through the ceiling, a scooter that won't start. In this room, a tap drips into a steel basin. Once every four seconds.

Widen. THE PROTAGONIST (early 20s) lies on a narrow bed, fully dressed, shoes still on. He is not asleep. He is watching the light.

He lifts a hand into the rectangle. The light lands on his palm. He turns it over, examines it as if it belongs to someone else. Lowers it.

His phone buzzes on the floor. He doesn't look at it.

The light reaches the edge of the wall and folds into the corner. Gone.

He keeps looking at where it was.

2. EXT. BUS STOP — EVENING

A crowded stop on a main road. Horns, a pressure-horn from a lorry, someone shouting a price.

The Protagonist stands slightly apart from the crowd. A bus arrives. Everyone surges. He lets them go first. The bus fills. The doors fold shut in front of him.

He waits for the next one. He doesn't seem to mind.

3. INT. BUS (MOVING) — EVENING

We are outside the bus, looking in through the window. The Protagonist sits on the far side. The glass carries a reflection of the street over his face: shop signs, a man on a scooter with a gas cylinder, a woman laughing into her phone.

Inside, he watches the reflections, not the street.

Across the aisle, an elderly woman asks a schoolboy a question we can't hear. The boy pauses before answering. A long, honest pause. The Protagonist watches that pause as if it's the most important thing he's seen all day.

The boy answers. The woman laughs. The Protagonist looks away, back to the glass.

4. INT. PROTAGONIST'S FLAT — KITCHEN — NIGHT

A small kitchen. Tube light, one of its ends flickering. THE MOTHER (50s) still wears her pharmacy tag on a lanyard. She is reheating rice and dal. She moves the way people move after twelve hours on their feet.

The Protagonist sits at the folding table. Two plates.

THE MOTHER: Did you go?

THE PROTAGONIST: Go where?

THE MOTHER: The interview. The insurance place. Your uncle's friend.

A pause.

THE PROTAGONIST: I went to the bus stop.

She turns off the flame. Doesn't turn around.

THE MOTHER: And then?

THE PROTAGONIST: The bus was full.

THE MOTHER: There's always another bus.

THE PROTAGONIST: I know. I took it.

THE MOTHER: And?

THE PROTAGONIST: It went somewhere else.

She brings the plates. Sits. Looks at him for a long moment. She is not angry. She is something more tired than angry.

THE MOTHER: Eat.

They eat. The tap drips in the bedroom. The tube light flickers.

THE MOTHER (CONT'D): He asked me what you want to do. Your uncle. At the wedding.

THE PROTAGONIST: What did you say?

THE MOTHER: I said you're thinking about it.

THE PROTAGONIST: That's true.

THE MOTHER: For three years it's been true.

He nods. Not defensive. Agreeing.

THE PROTAGONIST: What did you want to do? When you were my age.

She stops chewing. Thinks. Then laughs, short, through her nose.

THE MOTHER: Sleep.

She gets up and takes her plate to the sink.

5. EXT. ROOFTOP OF THE BUILDING — NIGHT

Water tanks, a tangle of TV cables, washing lines with clothes stiff from the day's heat. Far off, between two buildings, a thin dark strip that might be the sea.

The Protagonist and THE FRIEND (early 20s) sit on the parapet. The Friend talks with his hands, eats peanuts from a paper cone.

THE FRIEND: It's not even a big company. That's the thing. Everyone keeps saying congratulations like I've been made a minister. It's a logistics firm. I'm going to look at spreadsheets of where boxes are.

THE PROTAGONIST: You like knowing where things are.

THE FRIEND: I do like knowing where things are. *(beat)* That's actually a really good point. Don't make me feel good about it, I'm trying to be nervous.

The Protagonist smiles. A real one, brief.

THE FRIEND (CONT'D): You should come visit. When I've got a place. There's a lake. Apparently. I haven't seen it, I've seen a picture of it.

THE PROTAGONIST: When do you leave?

THE FRIEND: Six weeks. I told you this.

THE PROTAGONIST: You told me.

THE FRIEND: You were there. You were looking at a pigeon.

THE PROTAGONIST: It had one foot.

THE FRIEND: *(laughing)* It had one foot. Okay.

The Friend offers the peanuts. The Protagonist takes a few. Below them, a wedding procession passes, a brass band slightly out of tune, someone dancing badly in front.

The Friend leans over the edge to watch. Whoops at the dancer. The dancer waves up at him without knowing who he is.

The Protagonist doesn't lean over. He watches the Friend watching.

THE FRIEND (CONT'D): *(still looking down)* What are you going to do, man?

THE PROTAGONIST: Tonight?

THE FRIEND: Generally.

Long pause. The band turns a corner. The music thins.

THE PROTAGONIST: Do you ever feel like... everyone got a set of instructions, and mine got lost in the post?

The Friend turns. Considers it seriously.

THE FRIEND: No. *(beat)* I feel like nobody got instructions and some people are just better at pretending.

THE PROTAGONIST: That's worse.

THE FRIEND: Is it? I find it comforting.

He throws a peanut at a crow on the water tank. Misses.

6. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — DAY

The Mother stands in the doorway holding an empty suitcase.

THE MOTHER: The aunty upstairs needs a suitcase for her son. Clear the top of the cupboard. I want that one back.

She leaves it on the bed and goes.

7. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — CONTINUOUS

The Protagonist stands on a plastic chair, pulling things down from the top of a steel cupboard. Dust. A school bag. A cricket bat with a cracked handle. A guitar in a soft case, one string snapped and curled like a question mark. He looks at it a moment too long, then puts it on the bed.

At the very back, wrapped in a cotton dupatta, something heavy. He unwraps it.

An old camcorder. Silver, scratched, the kind with a flip-out screen and a tape cassette. A sticker on the side, sun-faded: a small hand-drawn flower.

8. INT. PROTAGONIST'S FLAT — KITCHEN — CONTINUOUS

The Mother is chopping onions. He appears in the doorway with the camera.

THE PROTAGONIST: Whose is this?

She glances. A tiny hesitation in the knife. Then it continues.

THE MOTHER: Mine. From before.

THE PROTAGONIST: Before what?

THE MOTHER: Before. *(beat)* It probably doesn't work.

THE PROTAGONIST: What did you film?

THE MOTHER: Things. *(she scrapes the onions into the pan)* Your grandmother. The street. Nonsense.

THE PROTAGONIST: Why did you stop?

The onions hiss. She stirs.

THE MOTHER: The tapes got expensive.

She doesn't look at him. He knows that's not the whole answer. He doesn't push.

THE MOTHER (CONT'D): There's a charger somewhere. In the drawer with the wires nobody knows about.

9. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — NIGHT

A drawer emptied onto the bed: chargers, cables, a remote for a television they no longer own.

One charger fits. A tiny red light comes on. He sits on the floor and waits, watching it, as if it might change its mind.

It turns green.

He flips the screen open. Presses record. The screen shows his own room: the bed, the wall, the dripping tap. Grainy, a little blue.

He turns the camera slowly across the room. On the little screen, the room looks different. Framed. As if it belongs to someone.

He turns it towards himself. His own face fills the screen. He looks at it for one second and immediately turns it away, towards the window.

Through the window: a neighbour's kitchen across the gap. A woman washing a single cup. She dries it, holds it up to the light, puts it away.

On the little screen, the protagonist watches her. He's breathing slightly differently.

10. EXT. STREETS — MORNING — A SERIES OF SHOTS

The Protagonist walks with the camcorder held at his chest. People glance at him. He films:

- Steam rising from a tea stall's kettle. The tea seller, without looking up, waves the steam away from his eyes.

- A school van with children's hands sticking out of every window.
- Two men carrying a mirror across the road. For a moment, the mirror holds the whole street, sliding.
- A dog asleep in the exact shape of a shadow.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: Each image is small, slightly shaky, the colours washed out. A date stamp in the corner blinks a year that's twenty-two years wrong.

The Protagonist stops at a crossing. Lowers the camera. For the first time, people are looking at him, not through him. A woman asks, half-curious, half-suspicious:

WOMAN AT CROSSING: Are you from the news?

THE PROTAGONIST: No.

WOMAN AT CROSSING: Then what are you filming?

He opens his mouth. Has nothing.

The light changes. She crosses. He doesn't.

11. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — NIGHT

He sits on the bed with a notebook. He writes something, crosses it out. Writes again.

INSERT — THE NOTEBOOK: *What do they know that I don't.* Under it, smaller: *People who keep going. Not famous. Just going.* Under that: *Find them. Watch.*

He looks at the words. Underlines *Watch.* Then, after a moment, underlines it again.

The tap drips.

He gets up, turns it tighter. It stops. The silence is enormous.

After four seconds: drip.

He almost laughs.

The Painter

12. EXT. OLD QUARTER — NARROW LANE — LATE MORNING

Wind off the sea pushes down the lane. Washing snaps on balconies.

THE PAINTER (70s), thin, in a paint-stained kurta and rubber slippers, is carrying a large stretched canvas, bigger than his own body. The wind catches it like a sail. He staggers, turns sideways, swears at it in a low, steady voice.

THE PAINTER: No. No. Don't you dare. I made you.

The Protagonist is at the end of the lane, camera half-raised. He watches. The wind gusts. The canvas tips. The Painter is about to go over with it.

The Protagonist lowers the camera and runs. Grabs the other edge. Together they steady it.

THE PAINTER (CONT'D): *(breathless, not grateful)* Not by the front. You'll put your thumb through it. The frame. Hold the frame.

The Protagonist adjusts. They carry it down the lane like two men carrying a door.

THE PAINTER (CONT'D): The framer said it was crooked. It's not crooked. *He* is crooked.

13. EXT. PAINTER'S HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

A narrow two-storey house, blue paint peeling to an older green underneath. A heavy wooden door. The Painter fumbles for a key on a string around his neck.

THE PAINTER: You can put it down. Gently. *Gently.* Like it's asleep.

They lean the canvas against the wall. It's blank. Stretched, primed, white.

THE PROTAGONIST: There's nothing on it.

THE PAINTER: Not yet. *(opening the door)* That's why it was so light.

He goes inside. Leaves the door open. The Protagonist isn't sure if that's an invitation. After a moment, the Painter's voice, from inside:

THE PAINTER (O.S.) (CONT'D): Well, bring it in, then.

14. INT. PAINTER'S HOUSE — STUDIO — CONTINUOUS

The ground floor is one long room. Light enters from a high window and a back door that opens onto a tiny courtyard with a papaya tree.

Canvases everywhere. Stacked against walls in rows ten deep, faces turned inward. Hanging on nails. Leaning on chairs. Some finished, most not. Jars of brushes. Tubes squeezed flat and rolled up from the bottom. A table with a kettle, a radio with a bent aerial, a plate with half a banana going brown.

On the wall, faded photographs pinned at angles: a young man in front of a gallery door. A woman laughing in a doorway. A group of art students sitting on steps.

The Protagonist props the new canvas against the only bare patch of wall. Turns around slowly. Takes it in.

THE PROTAGONIST: Are these all yours?

THE PAINTER: No, I steal them. *(he fills the kettle)* Tea? Don't say yes if you don't drink it. People say yes and then hold it until it's cold, and I have to throw it away. I hate throwing tea away.

THE PROTAGONIST: Yes. I'll drink it.

THE PAINTER: Hm.

The Protagonist stops in front of a canvas on an easel. A view of the sea from a window. Most of it is finished, careful, a little old-fashioned. But in the lower corner, where the water meets the frame, there's a small area, the size of a palm, that's unfinished. Several attempts at blue, layered and scraped back.

THE PROTAGONIST: What happened here?

The Painter glances over without coming closer.

THE PAINTER: That's the part that isn't right yet.

THE PROTAGONIST: It's tiny.

THE PAINTER: So is a stone in your shoe.

15. INT. PAINTER'S STUDIO — LATER

They drink tea. The Painter sits in a cane chair that creaks with every movement. The Protagonist sits on an upturned crate. The camcorder is in his lap.

THE PAINTER: So what is that? You're a journalist?

THE PROTAGONIST: Everyone asks that.

THE PAINTER: Because it's the only reason anyone carries a camera at a stranger.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'm... making something. A film. Maybe.

THE PAINTER: About?

He looks around the room. At the canvases with their faces to the wall.

THE PROTAGONIST: About people who keep doing things. When nobody's watching.

The Painter snorts into his tea.

THE PAINTER: Then you'll be very bored. Nobody watching is very boring. That's why it's nobody.

THE PROTAGONIST: Can I film you?

THE PAINTER: Doing what?

THE PROTAGONIST: Whatever you'd do anyway.

The Painter considers this. Squints at him.

THE PAINTER: I'd do nothing anyway. Today I'm doing nothing. I carried that thing from the framer and now my back is a pretzel. *(beat)* Come on Thursday. Thursday I do the boring part.

THE PROTAGONIST: What's the boring part?

THE PAINTER: All of it. Thursday's the most of it.

16. INT. PAINTER'S STUDIO — THURSDAY — MORNING

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: Grainy. A little blue. The Painter's hands soaking brushes in a jar of turpentine, working the bristles between finger and thumb. Wiping them on a rag. Laying them out on newspaper in order of size.

BACK TO SCENE. The film's own camera: wider, warmer. The Protagonist stands a few feet away, filming. The Painter talks without looking up.

THE PAINTER: Most people think painting is painting. It's ten per cent painting. The rest is washing things. *(he holds up a brush)* This one's older than you. Look at it. Bald as an egg. I keep it for the edges.

THE PROTAGONIST: Why not buy a new one?

THE PAINTER: A new one doesn't know the edges.

He goes on cleaning. The Protagonist films. A long, unbroken stretch of nothing much: the scrape of a palette knife, the radio murmuring news about a bridge, the papaya tree ticking against the courtyard wall.

17. INT. PAINTER'S STUDIO — DAY — SERIES OF SHOTS ACROSS SEVERAL VISITS

The Protagonist returns. Different shirts, same crate. The camcorder on its little screen. We see the visits through both cameras, his and ours.

- The Painter mixing colour on a glass slab. Blue. Then a touch of black. Then white. He shakes his head, scrapes it all off with the knife, starts again.
- The Painter sitting in front of the new blank canvas. Not moving. For a long time. The Protagonist films the stillness. Shifts his weight. Checks the battery.

- The Painter on a stool, working on the small unfinished patch of the sea painting with a brush no bigger than a matchstick. His breath held. His tongue, slightly, between his teeth.
- The Painter, frustrated, turning the sea painting to face the wall. Muttering.
- Three days later, turning it back.

18. INT. PAINTER'S STUDIO — AFTERNOON

Rain on the courtyard. The back door open, the smell of wet earth. The Painter is working on the blue patch again. The Protagonist films.

THE PROTAGONIST: Can I ask something?

THE PAINTER: You're going to.

THE PROTAGONIST: Who sees these?

The brush stops. Starts again.

THE PAINTER: Me.

THE PROTAGONIST: Besides you.

THE PAINTER: The man who comes to read the electricity meter. He liked the one with the goat. *(beat)* My daughter used to. She's in Canada. She sends photos of snow. I send photos of paintings. We are both very polite about it.

THE PROTAGONIST: Then why do you keep...

He gestures at the room. The hundreds of faces turned to the wall.

The Painter puts the brush down. Thinks. Not about the answer. About whether to bother answering.

THE PAINTER: I wanted to see what it would look like.

He picks the brush up again.

The Protagonist waits for more. It doesn't come.

THE PROTAGONIST: That's it?

THE PAINTER: What did you want? I'm seventy-three. I don't have speeches. I had one once, I gave it at my sister's wedding, it went badly.

THE PROTAGONIST: But you could have... I don't know. Sold them. Shown them somewhere.

The Painter's jaw tightens. A small flicker of something older than this conversation.

THE PAINTER: I was going to. Once. *(he dabs at the canvas)* Big gallery. In the capital. A man came, saw my work, said yes. I was thirty-one. I had a train ticket.

THE PROTAGONIST: What happened?

THE PAINTER: My father got sick. I didn't take the train. *(beat)* Then the man who said yes died. Then the gallery became a bank. Then I became seventy-three.

He says it plainly, almost a joke. He doesn't look up. The rain gets heavier.

THE PAINTER (CONT'D): Don't put that in your film. People love that kind of thing. Then they look at you like a sad dog.

THE PROTAGONIST: I won't.

THE PAINTER: You will. It's a good story. I'd put it in.

The Protagonist lowers the camera slightly. The little red light is still on.

19. INT. PAINTER'S STUDIO — LATER

The rain has stopped. Water drips from the papaya leaves.

The Painter is wrapping his brushes in a cloth. The Protagonist is putting the camera away.

THE PROTAGONIST: Does it ever... feel like enough? Just you seeing them?

The Painter ties a knot in the cloth. Slowly.

THE PAINTER: Some days. Some days I want to burn the whole house down and go and sell bananas. *(beat)* Most days I want to know what that blue is going to do.

THE PROTAGONIST: And when you find out?

THE PAINTER: Then I'll want to know what the next thing is going to do. That's the trap. *(he shrugs)* It's a comfortable trap. It has a chair.

He pats the arm of the cane chair. It creaks.

20. EXT. PAINTER'S HOUSE — EVENING

The Protagonist steps out into the lane. The heavy door closes behind him.

He stands there. Opens the camcorder. Rewinds. Watches the Painter's hands on the little screen. The tiny brush. The held breath.

He watches it as if it's evidence of something. He can't tell what.

Over his shoulder, behind him, through a gap in the door, we can still see the Painter, sitting in the cane chair, doing nothing, looking at the blue.

The Protagonist doesn't turn around.

The Musician

21. EXT. MARKET STREET — HARDWARE SHOP — EVENING

A street of small shops. Pipes, buckets, coils of rope, padlocks hanging like fruit. The hardware shop's SHOPKEEPER (60s) is pulling down a shutter halfway, arguing on the phone about a delivery of PVC.

Above the shop, a single window with a grille, lit yellow. From it: a guitar. The same four bars, over and over. Stopping. Starting. Stopping at exactly the same note each time.

The Protagonist stands across the street, looking up. He films the window. Just the window and the sound.

The passage stops again at the same note. A pause. Then, from the window, a single loud word we can't make out, and a hand slapping the body of the guitar.

The Shopkeeper, still on the phone, glances up at the window and shakes his head fondly.

SHOPKEEPER: *(to the Protagonist, covering the phone)* Eleven years. Same song. Never finishes it.

THE PROTAGONIST: Is that… good or bad?

SHOPKEEPER: He pays rent on time. *(back into the phone)* No, I said four-inch. *Four.*

22. INT. STAIRWELL ABOVE HARDWARE SHOP — CONTINUOUS

Narrow concrete stairs. A smell of machine oil and incense. The Protagonist climbs. A door at the top, slightly open. Inside, the passage again. It stops at the same place.

He knocks.

THE MUSICIAN (O.S.): It's open, it's always open, it doesn't close.

23. INT. MUSICIAN'S ROOM — CONTINUOUS

A small room. A mattress on the floor, neatly made. Egg cartons glued to one wall, badly, for soundproofing. A metronome. A stack of children's music books with cartoon notes on the covers. A plastic chair, a stool, an electric fan rotating slowly and clicking at the end of each turn.

THE MUSICIAN (40s) sits on the stool with an acoustic guitar. Spectacles pushed up into his hair. He looks at the Protagonist, then at the camera.

THE MUSICIAN: If you're from the building association, I already said I'll stop at ten.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'm not.

THE MUSICIAN: If you want lessons, it's Saturdays and you're too old.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'm too old?

THE MUSICIAN: For Saturdays. Saturdays are seven to twelve year olds. They'll destroy you. *(squints)* What's that?

THE PROTAGONIST: A camera.

THE MUSICIAN: I can see it's a camera. What is it for?

The Protagonist hesitates. He's practised this, since the Painter.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'm filming people who... practise. Things. For a long time.

THE MUSICIAN: And you heard me from the street.

THE PROTAGONIST: The shopkeeper said eleven years.

THE MUSICIAN: *(a laugh, short)* He exaggerates. It's nine. *(beat)* It's not the same song. It's the same bar. Different songs, same bar. There's always one bar.

He plays it. Four bars, fast, intricate, and on the last note his finger slips a fraction. A buzz. He closes his eyes.

THE MUSICIAN (CONT'D): There. That one.

THE PROTAGONIST: It sounded fine.

THE MUSICIAN: It sounded fine to you because you weren't waiting for it.

24. INT. MUSICIAN'S ROOM — NIGHT — SEVERAL VISITS

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: The Musician tuning. Head tilted, ear almost on the wood. Turning a peg a hair at a time. Plucking. Turning back.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: The Musician with the metronome set very slow. Playing the hard passage at half speed. Then a little faster. Then faster. Then failing. Back to slow.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: The Musician eating a samosa out of newspaper with one hand, still fingering chords on the neck with the other.

BACK TO SCENE. Our camera. The Protagonist sits on the plastic chair. The fan clicks. The Musician is changing a string, winding it carefully, swearing softly when it bites his thumb.

25. INT. MUSICIAN'S ROOM — NIGHT

The Musician plays the passage. Fails at the same note. He stops, looks at the ceiling, and starts laughing. Helplessly, at himself.

THE MUSICIAN: Nine years. Nine years, and this note looks at me like I owe it money.

The Protagonist, holding the camera, starts laughing too. He can't help it. The camera shakes. The Musician plays the note again, deliberately wrong this time, a comic honk, and they both laugh harder.

The Musician wipes his eyes. Starts the passage again. The Protagonist, still smiling, forgets for a moment to point the camera straight. It dips towards the floor, the fan, the egg cartons.

This moment passes. Neither of them remarks on it.

26. INT. MUSICIAN'S ROOM — LATER

The Musician sets the guitar flat across his knees. Drinks water from a steel bottle. The Protagonist films him.

THE PROTAGONIST: Do you ever regret it?

THE MUSICIAN: Regret what?

THE PROTAGONIST: All of this. The years. It hasn't... taken you anywhere.

The Musician looks at him. Not offended. Curious. He takes his time.

THE MUSICIAN: Where did you think I was trying to go?

The Protagonist opens his mouth. Closes it.

THE PROTAGONIST: I don't know. Somewhere... bigger?

THE MUSICIAN: Bigger than this room?

THE PROTAGONIST: Yes.

The Musician looks around his room. At the egg cartons, the mattress, the cartoon music books. As if checking it for size.

THE MUSICIAN: Hm.

That's all he says. He picks up the guitar and starts tuning again.

The Protagonist waits. The fan clicks. The Musician hums under his breath, finding the pitch. The Protagonist realises the answer isn't coming. He can't tell whether the question was rude or just boring.

THE MUSICIAN (CONT'D): *(not looking up)* I did try. To go somewhere. I was in a band. We played weddings, we played a hotel in the hills for one season. The drummer married the hotel owner's daughter. That was the end of the band. *(he plucks a string)* I was angry for maybe three years. Then I was a guitar teacher. Then I was a person who plays guitar above a hardware shop.

THE PROTAGONIST: Do you still want...

THE MUSICIAN: Some nights. *(beat)* Mostly I want the bar.

27. INT. PROTAGONIST'S FLAT — KITCHEN — MORNING

The Mother is packing her lunch in a steel tiffin. The Protagonist comes in, the camcorder hanging off his wrist by its strap. He's sleepy, energised.

THE MOTHER: You were out late.

THE PROTAGONIST: I was at the guitar man's.

THE MOTHER: Which guitar man?

THE PROTAGONIST: Above the hardware shop. On the market road.

She looks at him. Something softens and then hardens again, both at once.

THE MOTHER: And the painter man.

THE PROTAGONIST: Thursdays.

She closes the tiffin.

THE MOTHER: Your friend called. The landline. He said you're not answering your phone.

THE PROTAGONIST: I was filming.

THE MOTHER: He's leaving in a month.

THE PROTAGONIST: I know.

THE MOTHER: I know you know. *(she picks up her bag)* Does that thing still have the strap that breaks?

THE PROTAGONIST: It broke yesterday. I tied it.

She almost says something. Stops. Touches the knot on the strap with one finger on her way out, as if recognising it.

28. INT. MUSICIAN'S ROOM — NIGHT

Late. The window is open. The street below is quiet except for a distant dog and the occasional motorcycle.

The Musician is relaxed tonight. The Protagonist has brought tea in a plastic bag from a stall; they drink it from paper cups.

THE MUSICIAN: You want to hear something that isn't a bar?

THE PROTAGONIST: What is it?

THE MUSICIAN: Nothing. Something of mine. It doesn't have a name. Names are for things that are finished.

The Protagonist raises the camera. Frames him carefully. Checks the light. Presses record. Nods.

The Musician begins to play.

It's slow. A melody that seems to circle back on itself, then step somewhere unexpected. Not virtuosic. Warm. A little sad in the way an old room is sad. It fills the small space. The fan clicks in time without meaning to.

We stay on the Protagonist. At first he watches the little flip-out screen. Then, slowly, his eyes lift from the screen to the Musician himself. The camera drifts slightly down in his hands. The framing goes. He doesn't notice. He is just listening.

We hold on his face. A very long take. Something in it loosens. Not happiness. Presence.

The melody ends. Not a big ending. It just stops, the way a person stops talking when they've said enough.

Silence. The fan clicks. A motorcycle passes below.

The Protagonist blinks. And then, immediately, almost guiltily, he looks down at the camera. Checks the red light. Stops recording. Rewinds. Holds the little screen up to his face.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: The melody playing back through the tinny speaker. The image tilted, half the Musician's face, the egg cartons, a slice of the fan.

THE MUSICIAN: Did you get it?

THE PROTAGONIST: *(still looking at the screen)* Most of it. The frame slipped.

THE MUSICIAN: Hm.

The Protagonist watches the footage through to the end. Then rewinds and watches it again.

His face does something complicated. He is listening to the recording, and the recording is fine. But he is searching for something in it. He can't find it.

THE PROTAGONIST: *(quietly)* How did it go? The middle part.

THE MUSICIAN: You just heard it.

THE PROTAGONIST: I know. I... *(he stops)* I've got it here.

He taps the camera, as if that settles it. It doesn't.

The Musician watches him for a moment. Then picks up the guitar and goes back to the bar. The four hard notes. The slip. Again.

29. EXT. MARKET STREET — NIGHT

The Protagonist walks home under sodium lights. He has the camcorder's earphone in one ear. He's listening to the melody.

He stops under a streetlight. Takes the earphone out. Tries to hum the middle part.

He gets three notes. Then he's lost it.

He puts the earphone back in.

The Dancer

30. EXT. COMMUNITY HALL — EARLY AFTERNOON

A low colonial-era building with a tin-roofed verandah. A painted board: the name of a residents' association, half the letters faded. A noticeboard with a yoga timetable, a lost-cat poster, and an announcement for a blood donation camp held two years ago.

The Protagonist is passing. He stops. From inside: a rhythmic thud. Bare feet landing on wood. A pause. Thud. A pause. Then a laugh, alone, echoing.

31. INT. COMMUNITY HALL — CONTINUOUS

He pushes the door an inch.

A long, high-ceilinged room. Wooden floor, scuffed pale in places. Folding chairs stacked against one wall. Tall windows down one side with thin cotton curtains, and the afternoon light coming through them in slabs.

THE DANCER (mid-20s) is alone in the middle of the floor. Loose t-shirt, track pants rolled to the knee, a strip of physiotherapy tape on her left knee. A phone on a chair plays a track through its own small speaker.

She runs at a movement: a turn into a leap that should land soft and low. She lands, but her left leg takes it badly. She stumbles. Stands. Shakes the leg out. Laughs at the ceiling.

THE DANCER: *(to herself)* No, okay. Okay. You hate me today.

She walks back to her mark. Sees him in the doorway. Doesn't startle. Just looks.

THE DANCER (CONT'D): The yoga's on Tuesdays.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'm not here for yoga.

THE DANCER: Nobody is. Six aunties and one man who sleeps.

She drinks water. Wipes her face with the bottom of her t-shirt. Eyes the camera.

THE DANCER (CONT'D): Did the association send you? Because I paid. I paid for the whole month. The receipt is in my bag, he wrote it on the back of a bill.

THE PROTAGONIST: Nobody sent me.

THE DANCER: So you just walk into halls with that.

THE PROTAGONIST: Not usually.

She considers him. Not suspicious exactly. Amused.

THE DANCER: What do you want to film? I'm not performing. It's not a show. It's me falling over in an empty room.

THE PROTAGONIST: That's... sort of what I want.

THE DANCER: *(laughing)* You want me falling over.

THE PROTAGONIST: I want what you'd do if I wasn't here.

THE DANCER: If you weren't here I'd be swearing more.

THE PROTAGONIST: You can swear.

She thinks about it. Sets the phone's track back to the start.

THE DANCER: Stand over there. By the chairs. And if I land on you, that's your problem.

32. INT. COMMUNITY HALL — AFTERNOON — SEVERAL DAYS

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: The Dancer warming up on the floor. Rolling her ankles. Lying on her back with her knees up, breathing.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: The turn-into-leap. Again. Landing hard. Again. Landing slightly better. Again.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: She stops mid-phrase, walks off the floor, stands at the window eating an orange, segment by segment. Walks back and starts again without a word.

BACK TO SCENE. The Protagonist on a folding chair. A plastic bag of oranges between them on the floor now, a small habit already.

THE PROTAGONIST: Is it for something? A show? An audition?

THE DANCER: *(stretching)* No.

THE PROTAGONIST: Then...

THE DANCER: I work nights. At a call centre. Insurance claims for Australians. *(she does an accent, cheerful, flat)* "Thank you for your patience, I understand this is frustrating." Eight hours. Then I sleep till eleven. Then I come here.

THE PROTAGONIST: Why here?

She pulls her foot towards her head. Winces at the knee.

THE DANCER: Because otherwise the day's just... *(she looks for the word)* ...soup. Everything's the same temperature. This gives it a shape. *(beat)* And because I want to know how this works. *(she taps her own hip, her ribs)* I've had it twenty-five years. I still don't know what it can do.

THE PROTAGONIST: You trained? When you were small?

THE DANCER: Twelve years. Then my teacher moved to Dubai to teach rich kids, and my father said dancing was a hobby, and I said yes, okay, and I got a degree in commerce. *(she smiles)* I'm very good at commerce. Nobody has ever been less interested.

33. INT. COMMUNITY HALL — AFTERNOON

The Dancer is mid-sequence. The Protagonist films. She finishes, breathing hard. Comes to sit on the floor near his chair.

THE PROTAGONIST: What do you think about? While you're doing it.

She drinks water. Considers it honestly.

THE DANCER: Depends. Sometimes the count. *(she taps it on her thigh)* Sometimes my knee. Sometimes whether I left the gas on. Sometimes some Australian who shouted at me at four in the morning about his boat.

THE PROTAGONIST: And other times?

THE DANCER: Sometimes nothing.

He waits for her to explain. She doesn't. She peels an orange.

THE PROTAGONIST: Nothing.

THE DANCER: Mm.

THE PROTAGONIST: What does that… What's that like?

She looks at him as if he's asked what water tastes like.

THE DANCER: I don't know. I'm not there. *(she offers him a segment)* That's the point, I think. Or not the point. It's just what happens.

He takes the orange segment. Doesn't eat it. Holds it.

THE PROTAGONIST: I don't think I've ever thought about nothing.

THE DANCER: *(laughing, kindly)* Yeah. I can tell.

34. INT. COMMUNITY HALL — LATE AFTERNOON

The camera is on its little tripod now. A cheap one, legs held with tape. The Protagonist has set it up by the chairs, framing the whole floor.

The light in the hall is moving. The slabs through the windows have turned gold and lengthened, stretching across the boards.

The Dancer is working on the leap. And this time, once, she lands it. Soft. Low. Perfect. She freezes in the landing, as surprised as anyone. Then stands, very slowly, as if not to frighten it.

THE DANCER: *(whispering)* Did you see that?

THE PROTAGONIST: I saw it.

THE DANCER: Don't say anything. Don't say anything or it'll go.

She tries it again immediately. Lands badly. Laughs so hard she has to sit on the floor.

THE DANCER (CONT'D): It went.

35. INT. COMMUNITY HALL — CONTINUOUS

She's done for the day. She walks to the tall window and sits on the low sill, knees drawn up, breathing heavily, sweat drying. She looks down at the street below.

The Protagonist reaches for the camera to stop it. His hand is on the button.

He doesn't press it.

He sits back down. Neither of them speaks.

The film's camera holds a wide shot of the hall. The Dancer small at the window. The Protagonist small on the chair. The tripod between them, its red light on. The gold slabs of light crawling across the floor, a little further, a little further.

Outside: a pressure cooker whistles somewhere. A child is being called in for tea, repeatedly, by name. (We do not hear the name clearly.) A bicycle bell.

The Dancer's breathing slows. She rests her head against the window frame.

A long time. Maybe a minute and a half. Nothing happens.

The curtain beside her lifts slightly in a breeze and falls.

Finally, she stands. Picks up her bag.

THE DANCER: Same time tomorrow? I'm not coming Thursday, I have a double shift.

THE PROTAGONIST: Same time.

She goes. He sits there. The tripod is still recording the empty room. After a moment, he gets up and stops it.

36. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — NIGHT

The camcorder is connected by a cable to an old laptop, its plastic yellowed, one hinge loose. A capture program crawls, digitising tape in real time.

The Protagonist is watching the footage of the Dancer at the window.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: The hall in gold. The tiny figure on the sill. The curtain. The light moving.

He watches all of it. The whole minute and a half. He doesn't skip.

On his desk, other footage plays paused in another window: the Painter mixing colours, carefully composed, the light perfect. The Musician in a neat medium shot.

He looks from the composed shot to the window shot and back. He frowns, genuinely puzzled.

He rewinds the window footage and watches it again.

The tap drips. He doesn't notice it this time.

Act Two — Strangers

37. EXT. FLOWER MARKET LANE — PRE-DAWN

Dark blue. Streetlights still on. A truck unloading sacks of marigolds onto the road, the orange spilling in the headlights.

The Protagonist, hood up, yawning, camera ready.

A small flower shop, its shutter half-raised. Under it, a light. THE FLORIST (60s), sleeves rolled, sits on an overturned crate stripping leaves from rose stems with a knife, fast, without looking.

THE PROTAGONIST: Excuse me. I'm making a...

THE FLORIST: *(not looking up)* Closed.

THE PROTAGONIST: I don't want to buy anything.

THE FLORIST: Then very closed.

He stands there. She keeps stripping roses. Leaves pile at her feet.

THE PROTAGONIST: I wanted to film you opening the shop.

Now she looks up. Takes in the camera, his tired face, the hood.

THE FLORIST: Why?

THE PROTAGONIST: Because you're up before everyone.

THE FLORIST: The man who brings the marigolds is up before me. The man who grows the marigolds is up before him. Go and film the marigold farmer.

THE PROTAGONIST: He's not here.

She snorts. Points the knife at a bucket.

THE FLORIST: Fill that from the tap. If you're going to stand there, stand there usefully.

38. INT. FLOWER SHOP — DAWN

A tiny shop. Buckets of tuberoses, gerberas, lilies, chrysanthemums. A fridge humming with a glass door. A calendar from a fertiliser company, two years out of date. A framed photo of a man with a moustache, a dried garland around it.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: The Florist's hands binding a bouquet, wrapping wire round the stems, cutting the ends at an angle, all in one movement.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: Her pouring water from bucket to bucket. Throwing out wilted stems without a pause.

BACK TO SCENE. She talks while she works. The Protagonist now has wet sleeves; he's been made to carry buckets.

THE FLORIST: Forty-one years. My husband started it. *(nods at the photo)* He liked flowers. I didn't. I liked him. *(cutting stems)* Then he died, and I had a shop full of things that die in four days. So.

THE PROTAGONIST: So you kept going.

THE FLORIST: I kept opening the shutter. That's different.

THE PROTAGONIST: How?

THE FLORIST: Going sounds like you're going somewhere.

She sees him writing something in a small notebook. Rolls her eyes.

THE FLORIST (CONT'D): Don't write that down. It's not wise, I just woke up.

39. INT. FLOWER SHOP — LATER — MORNING

Bright now. A customer comes in: THE WIDOW (60s), neat sari, handbag held in both hands. The Florist sees her and, without a word, reaches for a particular bucket. White chrysanthemums. Begins wrapping a small bunch.

The Widow waits. Neither of them speaks. The Widow pays exact change. The Florist adds a sprig of something green she didn't charge for. The Widow notices. Nods. Goes.

The Protagonist, who has been filming, lowers the camera.

THE PROTAGONIST: Who was that?

THE FLORIST: Thursday.

THE PROTAGONIST: Who is she buying them for?

The Florist trims a stem.

THE FLORIST: I've never asked. *(beat)* Six years. Every Thursday. White. Small. *(she shrugs)* If she wanted to tell me, she would have.

THE PROTAGONIST: Aren't you curious?

THE FLORIST: Of course I'm curious. I'm not a stone. *(beat)* But she doesn't come here to be asked. She comes here to buy flowers.

The Protagonist looks at the camera in his hands. Looks at the doorway where the Widow went.

40. INT. CITY BUS (MOVING) — DAY

The front of a city bus. The Protagonist stands near the driver's cabin, gripping a pole, filming.

THE BUS DRIVER (late 50s), thick spectacles, a towel over his shoulder, a small plastic idol of a god glued to the dashboard beside a laminated photo of a grandchild. He drives with economy. Every gear change exact.

THE BUS DRIVER: Twenty-six years. Same route. Depot to the lighthouse and back. Seven times a day.

THE PROTAGONIST: Doesn't it get...

THE BUS DRIVER: Boring? *(he honks at an auto-rickshaw, two short beeps, almost polite)* Every day. *(beat)* Also, every day, something.

THE PROTAGONIST: Like what?

THE BUS DRIVER: Last week, a goat got on. At the temple stop. Nobody's goat. It rode four stops and got off at the vegetable market. Like it had business.

The Protagonist laughs. The Driver doesn't, but his eyes are smiling in the mirror.

THE BUS DRIVER (CONT'D): And a boy who used to go to school on my bus. Small. Now he goes to his office on my bus. He has a moustache. I don't know his name. He doesn't know mine. We nod.

THE PROTAGONIST: What will you do when you retire?

The Bus Driver's hands tighten slightly on the wheel. He changes gear.

THE BUS DRIVER: Two years. *(beat)* My wife says gardening. *(beat)* I don't like plants. They don't move.

He pulls into a stop. The doors hiss. People get off, people get on. He watches them all in his big mirror. Counts them, almost, with his eyes.

THE BUS DRIVER (CONT'D): *(quietly, maybe to himself)* I'll probably come and stand at the depot. Like a fool.

41. EXT. SEAFRONT PROMENADE — AFTERNOON

A long stone promenade. Benches facing the sea. Wind. Kites. Peanut sellers. Couples. Joggers in expensive shoes.

THE OLD COUPLE (80s) sit on a bench. He holds a folded newspaper open to the crossword and a pencil. She holds a thermos and two steel cups. They do not speak.

The Protagonist watches them from a distance through the viewfinder. A long time. The wind. They don't speak. He approaches.

THE PROTAGONIST: Excuse me. Would you mind if I...

THE OLD MAN: *(not looking up from the crossword)* Seven letters. "Remains unmoved."

THE PROTAGONIST: Sorry?

THE OLD WOMAN: He asks everybody. Ignore him.

THE OLD MAN: He might know.

THE OLD WOMAN: He doesn't know.

THE PROTAGONIST: *(thinking)* ..."Stoical"?

The Old Man counts on his fingers. Writes it in. Shows her. She looks. Looks away at the sea, unimpressed.

THE OLD WOMAN: It's "endures." No, that's seven. *(counting)* That's seven. Hm.

THE OLD MAN: Both are seven.

THE OLD WOMAN: Then it's whichever fits with nine down, which you got wrong.

THE OLD MAN: I didn't get nine down wrong.

THE OLD WOMAN: Fifty-one years. You've got nine down wrong every single day.

The Protagonist laughs. They both look at him as if they'd forgotten he was there.

THE OLD MAN: What's the camera for?

THE PROTAGONIST: I'm... filming people. Whose lives... *(he gives up on the explanation)* Can I sit for a bit?

THE OLD WOMAN: It's a public bench.

He sits at the far end. Films. They go back to their silence. The Old Woman pours tea. Gives him a cup without asking. He takes it.

42. EXT. SEAFRONT PROMENADE — SAME — LATER

The light lowering. The tea finished. The Old Man asleep with the newspaper on his chest. The Old Woman watching the sea.

THE PROTAGONIST: *(quietly)* Do you two ever... talk?

THE OLD WOMAN: We talked for forty years. *(beat)* We've said most of it.

THE PROTAGONIST: Isn't that... sad?

She looks at him as if he's a little stupid and a little sweet.

THE OLD WOMAN: You think silence is empty. *(beat)* It's full. It's very full. It's got everything in it already.

The Old Man snores once. She reaches over without looking and pulls the newspaper straight over him so the wind won't take it.

THE OLD WOMAN (CONT'D): Besides, he's very boring when he talks.

43. INT. NIGHT BUS (MOVING) — NIGHT

Almost empty. Tube lights. A sleepy CONDUCTOR. The Protagonist at the back, camera on his lap, recording the window, the dark city sliding.

Near the front, THE YOUNG PARENT (late 20s), still in a security guard's uniform, holds his DAUGHTER (4) asleep against his chest. Her shoe dangles from one foot. He is so tired his own eyes keep closing, and every time his head drops, he jerks awake and tightens his arms around her.

The Protagonist lifts the camera. Frames them. Then lowers it slightly. Hesitates.

He raises it again.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: The father and child, small at the far end of the bus. The father's head dropping. Jerking up. Arms tightening.

The bus stops. The father stands carefully, cradling the sleeping girl. Her shoe falls off. Hits the floor. He can't bend to get it.

The Protagonist has the camera on it. For a second, he keeps filming. The father looks at the shoe helplessly.

The Protagonist puts the camera down, goes forward, picks up the shoe, and gently puts it back on the girl's foot. The father nods, too tired for words. Gets off.

The Protagonist returns to his seat. Picks up the camera. It has been recording the whole time, pointing at the empty seat in front.

44. EXT. MARKET STREET — NIGHT

The market closing. Shutters coming down. Puddles. Rotting vegetables in a heap.

THE VENDOR (40s) is restacking unsold mangoes on a wooden handcart, counting out loud.

THE VENDOR: Thirty-two... thirty-three... and those two are finished... thirty-three.

He sees the camera. Points at it with a mango.

THE VENDOR (CONT'D): You want to film something? Film this. *(he holds up a bruised mango)* Bought at forty, selling at nothing. Film that. Put that on television.

THE PROTAGONIST: It's not for television.

THE VENDOR: Then what's the use?

The Protagonist doesn't have an answer. The Vendor goes back to counting.

THE VENDOR (CONT'D): Bad day. Rain in the morning, nobody comes. Police in the afternoon, I have to move. Evening, everybody wants bargains. *(he laughs, without bitterness)* Tomorrow will be better. *(beat)* That's what I said yesterday.

THE PROTAGONIST: Why do you keep...

THE VENDOR: *(cutting him off, cheerful)* My son is in eleventh standard. Science. *(he places a mango carefully, best side up)* That's why.

He arranges the remaining mangoes into a perfect pyramid. Even though the market is closing. Even though nobody will see it. He steps back and looks at it.

THE VENDOR (CONT'D): Nice, no?

THE PROTAGONIST: Very nice.

The Vendor throws a tarpaulin over it.

45. INT. FRIEND'S HOUSE — FRIEND'S ROOM — DAY

Chaos. Cardboard boxes, half-packed. Clothes on the bed. A cricket trophy wrapped in a towel.

The Friend is taping a box. The Protagonist sits on the floor, camera in hand, filming.

THE FRIEND: Are you going to help or are you just going to make a documentary of me suffering?

THE PROTAGONIST: Can I do both?

THE FRIEND: Give me that tape. *(he takes it)* You know what my mother said? She said, "Don't eat outside food every day." That's it. Twenty-three years and that's the big farewell advice.

THE PROTAGONIST: That's good advice.

THE FRIEND: It's terrible advice! There's nothing else to eat! *(he stops, sits on a box)* Why are you filming this?

The Protagonist pauses. Doesn't lower the camera.

THE PROTAGONIST: Because you're leaving.

The Friend looks at him. Then into the lens. Something shifts on his face.

THE FRIEND: I'm right here, though. *(beat)* I'm here for three more weeks. You could just... be here.

The Protagonist hears it. Doesn't quite understand it yet. Keeps filming.

The Friend looks away and keeps taping. Too much tape. The roll squeals.

46. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — NIGHT

The notebook again. Pages now. Lists.

INSERT — THE NOTEBOOK: *Painter — the work. Musician — the bar. Dancer — nothing (?). Florist — opening the shutter. Driver — something every day. Old couple — silence full. Vendor — the son. The pyramid.* At the bottom, circled: *What connects them?*

He stares at it. Draws an arrow from one word to another. Erases it. Draws a different arrow.

On the laptop beside him, a folder of footage. Forty-three files. Then fifty. He scrolls through them.

He's excited. He's also, somehow, frightened.

Midpoint — The Edit

47. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — NIGHT

The room has changed. A second-hand external hard drive, humming. A clip-on LED light. The taped tripod, now with a proper head bought from a repair stall. Tapes labelled in marker: PAINTER 1–9. MUSICIAN 1–6. DANCER 1–7. FLORIST. BUS. BENCH. MANGOES.

On the wall above the bed, where the sunlight falls in the afternoon, index cards pinned in rows. Each card: a scene, a face, a word. ARTISAN. DEVOTION. LOSS. PRESENCE. A line of string connecting some of them.

The Protagonist sits at the laptop in the blue glow. A cracked editing program. A timeline stacked with clips.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: The Painter mixing blue. The colour is cold and grey on the tape. The Protagonist drags a slider. The blue deepens, becomes saturated, beautiful, the way blue looks in memory.

He drags another slider. The Painter's skin warms. The studio looks golden, painterly, like an advertisement for sincerity.

He leans back. Looks at it. Likes it. Doesn't trust that he likes it.

48. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — LATER

3:12 a.m. on the laptop clock.

He's trying music under the clip. A piano piece downloaded from a free library: soft, swelling, emotional. He plays it over the Painter cleaning brushes.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: The Painter's hands in turpentine. The piano rising. Suddenly the hands look heroic. Tragic. Meaningful.

The Protagonist watches. He feels it. The music makes him feel it.

He stops the playback. Silence. The tap drips.

He plays it again without the music. The Painter's hands in turpentine. The scrape. The radio murmuring about the bridge. Plain.

He puts the music back on.

49. INT. PROTAGONIST'S FLAT — KITCHEN — MORNING

The Mother is leaving for work. The Protagonist is at the table, eyes red, eating cereal from the box.

THE MOTHER: Did you sleep?

THE PROTAGONIST: A bit.

THE MOTHER: What are you making? Really. All those cards on the wall.

He thinks. He actually wants to tell her.

THE PROTAGONIST: A film about why people… keep going. When nothing's happening for them. The painter. The guitar man. A woman who dances. A flower seller.

THE MOTHER: And why do they?

THE PROTAGONIST: I don't know yet. That's why I'm making it.

She stands in the doorway, bag on her shoulder.

THE MOTHER: And when you know?

THE PROTAGONIST: Then I'll… *(he doesn't know how that sentence ends)* Then I'll know.

She nods slowly. She looks at the camcorder on the table. The little flower sticker.

THE MOTHER: Your friend's dinner. It's Saturday.

THE PROTAGONIST: I know.

THE MOTHER: Eight o'clock. His mother called me to make sure.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'll be there.

She goes. He opens the laptop again.

50. INT. PAINTER'S STUDIO — DAY

The Protagonist arrives with the tripod and the clip light. He sets them up before saying hello. The Painter watches from the cane chair.

THE PAINTER: You've brought furniture.

THE PROTAGONIST: The light in here is uneven. In the footage it goes muddy on the left.

THE PAINTER: The light in here is the light in here.

THE PROTAGONIST: I know. It's just... on camera.

He clips the light to a shelf. Switches it on. The Painter squints.

THE PAINTER: Like an interrogation.

THE PROTAGONIST: Sorry. One minute. *(adjusting)* Could you sit at the easel? The sea one?

The Painter gets up slowly. His back. Sits at the easel. Picks up the tiny brush.

THE PROTAGONIST (CONT'D): Can you do the thing you do... where you hold your breath before the stroke?

THE PAINTER: I don't do a thing.

THE PROTAGONIST: You do. I've got it on tape. You go still and then you...

THE PAINTER: I don't know what I do. I'm busy doing it.

He paints. A small stroke. The Protagonist watches the screen.

THE PROTAGONIST: Could you do that again? A bit slower? Your hand went out of the light.

The Painter looks at him. Puts the brush down. A long moment.

THE PAINTER: The paint's already there now. If I do it again, it's a different stroke.

THE PROTAGONIST: Just... the movement. You don't have to touch the canvas.

The Painter's face is unreadable. Then, almost as a favour, almost as a joke, he mimes the stroke. In the air. An inch from the canvas.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: Perfectly lit. Beautifully framed. The old hand, the tiny brush, a stroke into nothing.

The Protagonist checks it. Nods.

THE PROTAGONIST: That's perfect. Thank you.

The Painter doesn't answer. He picks up a rag, wipes the brush that didn't touch anything.

51. INT. MUSICIAN'S ROOM — NIGHT

The tripod, the clip light, an extra microphone balanced on a stack of the children's music books.

The Musician is playing the melody, the nameless one. The Protagonist has asked for it. The Musician is a little stiff, aware.

Halfway, he fumbles. A wrong chord. He winces, keeps going, finishes.

THE PROTAGONIST: Could we do it once more? The middle went.

THE MUSICIAN: It went somewhere else. That happens.

THE PROTAGONIST: I need it clean. For the sequence. I'm going to use it over the bus driver and the old couple, I've timed it, there's a moment where...

He stops himself. The Musician is looking at him.

THE MUSICIAN: Over the bus driver.

THE PROTAGONIST: It's... a montage. Of people. It's the emotional centre. It's your song under all of them.

The Musician considers this. Something passes over his face. Flattered, a little. And something else.

THE MUSICIAN: It's not a song.

THE PROTAGONIST: The melody.

THE MUSICIAN: It's different every time. That's the only thing it is.

THE PROTAGONIST: I know. I just need one version that's... right.

The Musician plays it again. Clean this time. Careful. Every note in place.

It's perfect. It's lifeless. Both of them can hear it. Neither says so.

THE PROTAGONIST (CONT'D): Great. That's great. Thank you.

52. INT. COMMUNITY HALL — AFTERNOON

Tripod. Light. The Protagonist has marked a spot on the floor with blue tape: an X.

THE DANCER: What's that?

THE PROTAGONIST: That's where the light's best. At four. If you land there, the shadow from the window frame doesn't cut you in half.

THE DANCER: It's always cut me in half. I'm used to it.

THE PROTAGONIST: In the footage from Tuesday, your best one, the leap, your face is in the shadow. You can't see your face.

THE DANCER: I couldn't see my face either. I was busy with my legs.

She's joking. He doesn't laugh.

THE PROTAGONIST: Could you try to land on the X?

She looks at the tape. Then at him. She tries. The leap. She looks down for the X as she lands, and the movement breaks. She stumbles.

THE DANCER: I can't look for it and do it.

THE PROTAGONIST: Just once more.

She tries. Lands on the X. Stiffly. Careful of the knee. It's on the mark. It's lit. Her face is in the light.

It's nothing like the leap from Tuesday.

She walks to the chair and drinks water without looking at him.

53. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — NIGHT — SATURDAY

The laptop clock: 7:41 p.m.

He is cutting the montage. The perfect version of the melody, laid under images: the Bus Driver's hands, the Old Couple on the bench, the Florist's knife, the Vendor's pyramid. Each cut lands on a beat. He nudges a clip by two frames. Plays it. Nudges it back.

The phone buzzes on the bed. He glances. THE FRIEND. He lets it buzz. Thinks: one more minute.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: The montage plays. The melody, clean and swelling. The Old Woman pouring tea. A cut. The Driver's mirror. A cut. The Vendor's mango, best side up. It's moving. It's polished. It looks like something.

The clock: 8:36.

The phone buzzes again. A message preview on the lock screen: *bro are you coming. mum made the prawns.*

He types: *10 mins.*

He goes back to the timeline.

The clock: 9:52.

54. EXT. FRIEND'S BUILDING — NIGHT

The Protagonist hurrying up the road. Out of breath. The building's ground floor flat: lights still on, but the voices are thin, the dinner over. Through the window, the Friend's mother clearing plates.

The Friend is sitting on the building's front steps alone, eating the last of something sweet from a steel bowl.

He looks up. Sees the Protagonist. Doesn't get up.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'm sorry. I was... I lost track.

THE FRIEND: You were editing.

THE PROTAGONIST: I was editing.

The Friend nods. Scrapes the bowl.

THE FRIEND: There's prawns left. She saved some. In a box. *(beat)* Mum likes you. She kept asking.

The Protagonist sits on the step beside him. Neither speaks for a moment.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'll come to the station. Tuesday. I'll be there.

THE FRIEND: Okay.

THE PROTAGONIST: I mean it.

THE FRIEND: I said okay.

He doesn't sound angry. He sounds like someone who has decided not to need something.

The Protagonist notices, for the first time, that he doesn't have the camera with him. He left it at home, plugged into the laptop. His hands don't know what to do.

Withdrawal

55. INT. MUSICIAN'S ROOM — NIGHT

The Protagonist climbs the stairs. The bar is playing above him. The four hard notes. The slip. Again.

He enters. The Musician nods hello, keeps playing.

The Protagonist sets up the tripod quietly in the corner. Clips on the light. Presses record. The small red light comes on.

The Musician's eyes flick to it. His hands keep going, two more bars. Then they slow. Then they stop.

He reaches for the water bottle. Drinks. Takes a long time about it.

THE MUSICIAN: Tea?

THE PROTAGONIST: I'm fine. Keep going, I'm just...

THE MUSICIAN: I'm going to make tea.

He gets up and goes to the little gas ring in the corner. The red light records an empty stool and a guitar lying across it.

The Protagonist waits. The Musician makes the tea slowly. Hums. Not the melody. Some film song from the nineties, absent-minded.

He brings two cups. Sits on the mattress, not the stool. Away from the frame.

THE MUSICIAN (CONT'D): The kids on Saturday asked about you. The little one. She thinks you're from television.

THE PROTAGONIST: I keep telling people I'm not.

THE MUSICIAN: She told the others I'm going to be famous. *(beat)* I had to tell her no. She cried. *(he sips)* Seven years old and already disappointed by me. It's a record.

He smiles. It's a joke. Partly.

The Protagonist glances at the empty stool in the frame.

THE PROTAGONIST: Will you play some more?

THE MUSICIAN: Later.

They drink tea. The red light records the stool. Later doesn't come.

56. INT. COMMUNITY HALL — AFTERNOON

The blue tape X is still on the floor, scuffed at one corner. The Dancer is stretching on the far side of the hall, nowhere near it.

The Protagonist comes in with the tripod. She sees it. She stands.

THE DANCER: Can I ask you something?

THE PROTAGONIST: Sure.

THE DANCER: Could you not, today?

He stops halfway through unfolding the tripod legs.

THE PROTAGONIST: Not film?

THE DANCER: Not today. *(beat)* Actually... maybe not for a while.

THE PROTAGONIST: Did I do something?

She thinks about how to say it. She's not angry. She's being careful with him, which is worse.

THE DANCER: When you first came, it was like you weren't there. In a good way. I forgot. *(beat)* Now I don't forget. I land and I'm thinking, was that the X? Was my face in the light? I'm watching myself the way you watch me. *(beat)* And I don't come here to be watched. I watch people all night. I'm a voice on a headset for eight hours. This is the only place I'm not... for someone.

He stands there holding the half-opened tripod.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'm sorry.

THE DANCER: Don't be sorry. It's not a crime. *(she tries to smile)* It's just... my hall.

THE PROTAGONIST: It's not your hall. You rent it on Tuesdays.

It's a joke. It comes out wrong. She laughs anyway, briefly, generously.

THE DANCER: Let's get chai. Outside. Before I start.

She goes out through the side door onto the verandah. He looks at the tripod. He's already pressed record without thinking; the red light is on. He sets it down by the chairs, facing the empty floor, and follows her out.

We stay inside.

The empty hall. The tripod, recording. The afternoon light through the tall windows. Distantly, from the verandah, their voices: hers, then his, the words lost. A laugh: hers.

We do not go out to them. We wait with the camera.

57. EXT. COMMUNITY HALL — VERANDAH — CONTINUOUS

A chai seller's flask on a bicycle at the gate. Two glasses.

The Dancer and the Protagonist sit on the verandah steps. She has her knee stretched out in front of her.

THE DANCER: You know what you look like? With that camera?

THE PROTAGONIST: What?

THE DANCER: Like someone at a wedding who's filming the whole thing on his phone. And at the end of the night he's got it all. And he never danced.

He looks into his glass.

THE DANCER (CONT'D): That's not an insult. I've been that person. *(beat)* Everyone's been that person.

THE PROTAGONIST: Then what do I do?

THE DANCER: I don't know. *(she drinks)* I'm not your teacher. I can barely land a leap.

She hands him her empty glass and stands, testing the knee.

THE DANCER (CONT'D): You can stay and watch. Just... with your eyes.

She goes in. He sits on the step holding two empty glasses.

He doesn't go back in. After a while, he gets up and leaves. Forgets the tripod.

58. EXT. RAILWAY STATION — PLATFORM — EARLY MORNING — TUESDAY

A long platform. Vendors with steel kettles. Porters in red. A train breathing, its doors open.

The Friend with two suitcases and his PARENTS. His mother is crying and pretending she has dust in her eye. His father is giving a porter instructions he doesn't need.

The Protagonist arrives, running. He's made it. He has the camcorder in his hand. He's already filming as he approaches.

CAMCORDER FOOTAGE: The Friend turning. Seeing him. A huge grin. Then the grin stalls as he sees the lens.

BACK TO SCENE.

THE FRIEND: You came.

THE PROTAGONIST: I said I would.

THE FRIEND: You did say. *(he looks at the camera)* Put it down for one second.

The Protagonist hesitates. Lowers it. Lets it hang by the knotted strap.

The Friend hugs him. Hard. The awkward, back-slapping hug of two young men who don't know how to do this. It goes on a beat longer than either expected. The Protagonist's arms are stiff. Then, slowly, they aren't.

The whistle. The Friend's father calling.

THE FRIEND (CONT'D): *(stepping back)* Visit. I mean it. There's a lake.

THE PROTAGONIST: You've only seen a picture.

THE FRIEND: Then we'll find out together.

He climbs on. The train begins to move. He leans out of the door, waving.

The Protagonist's hand goes to the camera. Lifts it halfway. The train is sliding away. This is the shot. The receding train, the waving friend, the morning light.

He holds it halfway. Doesn't raise it.

He waves instead. Badly. Late. The train is already small.

The Friend's mother, beside him, blowing her nose, glances at the Protagonist and pats his arm without a word.

59. EXT. LANE OUTSIDE PAINTER'S HOUSE — DAY

The Protagonist walks down the narrow lane. Tripod over his shoulder. Camera bag. Clip light. He's carrying more equipment than the Painter carried canvas.

He knocks on the heavy door. A long wait. Footsteps. The door opens.

The Painter looks at him. At the tripod.

THE PAINTER: It's not Thursday.

THE PROTAGONIST: I know. I need the blue painting. Him working on it. I've got everything except the end of that thread. I need to show where it goes.

THE PAINTER: Where it goes.

THE PROTAGONIST: Whether you finish it. Or you don't. Either way, I need to film it. It's the ending. Maybe.

The Painter doesn't move from the doorway.

60. INT. PAINTER'S STUDIO — CONTINUOUS

The Protagonist has come in past him, slightly, the way someone does when they've been coming for weeks. He's unfolding the tripod.

THE PAINTER: No.

The Protagonist looks up.

THE PROTAGONIST: Sorry?

THE PAINTER: Not today. *(beat)* Leave the stand folded.

THE PROTAGONIST: It'll take half an hour. I'll set up quickly, you won't even...

THE PAINTER: No.

He sits down in the cane chair. It creaks. He looks tired. Older than in the first scenes.

The Protagonist stands with the tripod half-open. Again.

THE PROTAGONIST: Is it the light? I'll use natural light. I'll...

THE PAINTER: It's not the light.

Silence. The papaya leaves tick against the courtyard wall.

THE PROTAGONIST: Then why?

The Painter looks at him for a long time. He seems to be deciding whether to say it at all. When he does, it's almost gentle. Hesitant. Like a man handing back something that was lent to him.

THE PAINTER: You used to come and sit.

THE PROTAGONIST: I still...

THE PAINTER: You used to come and sit on that crate and drink my tea and ask silly questions. *(beat)* Now you come... and you want something from me.

The Protagonist opens his mouth.

THE PAINTER (CONT'D): I'm not angry. I'm old. Everyone wants something. *(beat)* But I thought you came because you liked it here.

The Protagonist can't answer. He looks around the room. The canvases, faces to the wall. The tea things. The crate he used to sit on, now with a light stand leaning on it.

He looks at the sea painting on the easel. The small patch of blue has changed. It's further along than he's ever seen it. Something has happened in it, and he wasn't here to see it, and he wasn't filming.

THE PROTAGONIST: *(quietly)* You've worked on it.

THE PAINTER: I work on it every day. *(beat)* Not just Thursdays.

The Protagonist nods. He folds the tripod. Slowly. The legs click shut one by one.

He doesn't apologise. He doesn't argue. He picks up his bags.

At the door, he turns. Wants to say something. Nothing comes.

THE PAINTER (CONT'D): *(not unkind)* Shut it properly. It sticks.

61. EXT. LANE OUTSIDE PAINTER'S HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

He pulls the door. It sticks. He pulls harder. It shuts.

He stands in the lane. Wind off the sea. The washing snapping on the balconies. A woman across the lane beating a rug with a stick.

His hand moves towards the camera bag. Stops.

There is nothing here he can film that would hold what just happened. He knows it.

He walks away. We stay on the closed blue door, the green underneath, for a long moment after he's gone.

Act Three — The Room

62. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — DAY

The curtains are drawn. The room is dim, lit by the laptop and the small green lights of the hard drive.

Tapes in piles. Index cards on the wall, some fallen, some re-pinned in new places, the string re-routed so many times the wall is a web.

The Protagonist sits on the floor with his back against the bed. Unshaven. The same t-shirt as two scenes ago.

Through a gap in the curtains, the afternoon rectangle of sunlight appears on the wall. It falls across the index cards. He doesn't look at it.

63. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — NIGHT

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: A timeline. A title card he's made: plain white letters on black. Under it, the film begins. The Florist's shutter rising. The music. The Painter's hands. The Musician's clean, perfect melody. The Dancer landing on the X.

It runs. It's handsome. It's coherent.

He reaches the end of the cut. The final shot: the Painter, perfectly lit, miming a brushstroke an inch from the canvas. The music swells. Fade to black.

He sits in the dark of the finished cut.

The screen reflects his face.

He drags the Painter's ending off the timeline. Drops in the Musician instead: the clean melody, a slow push-in on his face.

Plays it. The film now ends on music. On passion. On "do what you love."

He winces. Drags it off.

Drops in the Dancer at the window. Plays it. The film now ends on stillness. On presence. On "live in the moment."

He watches. Puts his hand over his mouth. Shakes his head.

He drags it off. The timeline ends abruptly in black. No ending at all.

64. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — NIGHT — LATER

The notebook. A new page.

INSERT — THE NOTEBOOK: *If painter: art saves you. (It didn't. He missed the train.) If musician: follow your passion. (He did. It went nowhere. He's fine?) If dancer: be present. (She works nights for Australians.) If florist: keep opening the shutter. (Why?)* Under it, in pressed, heavy pen: *They're not answers. They're just people.* And under that, smaller: *Then what was I looking for.*

He closes the notebook. Lies back on the floor. Stares at the ceiling. The fan isn't on. Everything is still.

The tap drips.

65. EXT. PROTAGONIST'S BUILDING — GATE — DAY

The watchman, an elderly man in a peaked cap, calls up as the Protagonist comes down the stairs with a rubbish bag.

WATCHMAN: Something for you. A girl left it.

He points. Leaning against the gate post: the taped tripod. Tied to one leg with a hair elastic, a scrap of paper.

INSERT — THE NOTE: *You forgot your legs. Knee is better. Come by sometime. Without these. — D*

The Protagonist reads it twice. Then he remembers: the camcorder had been sitting on top of the tripod, still recording, when he walked out of the hall.

A cloth bag hangs from the gate post beside it. Inside, the camcorder, wrapped in a spare t-shirt.

He presses the power button. Nothing. The battery is dead. Through the little window on its side, the tape is still there, wound almost to the end. He puts it in his pocket without looking at it again.

66. INT. PROTAGONIST'S FLAT — KITCHEN — NIGHT

The Mother comes home late. Drops her bag. Finds the Protagonist in the kitchen, standing at the counter eating dry bread from the packet in the dark.

She switches on the tube light. It flickers.

THE MOTHER: There's sambar in the fridge.

THE PROTAGONIST: I know.

THE MOTHER: It's from Sunday. It's fine. I smelled it.

She takes it out. Heats it. He watches. She gives him a bowl. He sits. She sits.

THE MOTHER (CONT'D): You've been in that room for nine days.

THE PROTAGONIST: Eight.

THE MOTHER: Eight. *(beat)* Is the film finished?

THE PROTAGONIST: No.

THE MOTHER: What's left?

THE PROTAGONIST: The ending.

THE MOTHER: Just the ending. That's good.

THE PROTAGONIST: It's not good. It's... the whole thing. If the ending's wrong, the whole thing's wrong. It's saying something I don't believe.

She eats. Waits.

THE PROTAGONIST (CONT'D): I thought if I watched them enough, I'd see it. What they have. What they know. *(beat)* They don't know anything. The painter's lonely. The guitar man is angry with himself every night. The dancer's knee is going. The flower lady talks to

a photo. *(he pushes the bowl)* And they're all... more... I don't know. More here than me.

The Mother doesn't answer immediately. She puts her spoon down.

THE PROTAGONIST (CONT'D): What did you film? Before. On that camera.

She looks at the table for a while.

THE MOTHER: Everything. For one year. *(beat)* The year before you were born. Your grandmother. The river near her house. Your father's scooter. Nothing.

THE PROTAGONIST: Where are the tapes?

THE MOTHER: I don't know. *(a small shrug)* In a box. Somewhere. At your uncle's, maybe. I never watched them.

THE PROTAGONIST: Never?

THE MOTHER: Never. *(beat)* I remember that year very well, though.

She doesn't explain. She gets up and puts her bowl in the sink. Runs water.

He sits there, looking at her back.

THE MOTHER (CONT'D): *(not turning)* Eat the sambar. It's from Sunday.

67. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — LATE NIGHT

He can't sleep. He's on the floor again, laptop on his knees, scrolling through the raw folders. Not the edit. The raw tapes. Hours of them.

He's not looking for anything. He's just scrolling. Like flipping through a photo album after a funeral.

A file name: MUSICIAN_04_raw. He clicks it.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: The Musician's room. The bar. Four hard notes. The slip. The Musician looking at the ceiling, laughing. "Nine years, and this note looks at me like I owe it money." Then, from behind the camera, the Protagonist's own laughter, loud, unguarded. The image shakes. The Musician plays the wrong note on purpose, the comic honk. The laughter doubles. The camera tilts down. The floor. The fan. The egg cartons. The image is a mess. The sound is a mess.

It's the most alive thing in the folder.

The Protagonist watches it. Doesn't move.

It ends. He plays it again.

He's not analysing it. He isn't taking notes. He's just remembering. The room. The tea. The way the fan clicked. His own stomach hurting from laughing.

He plays it a third time. On the screen, his laughter, younger by only a few weeks, but younger.

He smiles. Very small. Then his face crumples, briefly, and recovers. He wipes his nose on his wrist.

68. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — CONTINUOUS — A SEQUENCE

He goes back through the raw tapes. Slowly. Not cutting. Watching.

And now we see, with him, what was in the footage all along. Small things. Moments in the edges of frames he composed around.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: PAINTER_02_raw. The Painter, cleaning brushes. In the background, out of focus, his hand drifting to one of the faded photographs on the wall. The woman laughing in the doorway. He straightens its corner with one finger without looking at it. Goes back to the brushes.

The Protagonist pauses the frame. Leans close. He never saw it. He was filming the hands.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: FLORIST_01_raw. The Florist binding a bouquet. In the corner of the frame, through the doorway, a small boy in a school uniform walking past with his mother. He stops. Sniffs, dramatically, at a bucket of tuberoses. His mother pulls him on. The Florist, without looking up, smiles.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: BENCH_01_raw. The Old Couple. The wind. The Old Woman reaching over to straighten the newspaper on her sleeping husband. The Protagonist used this shot in the edit. But in the raw version, after the moment he cut, she leaves her hand there. On his chest. For eleven seconds. Then takes it back and pours herself more tea.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: BUS_02_raw. The Bus Driver at a stop. A woman getting on with a sack of rice, struggling. The Driver, irritated, sighing loudly, gets out of his seat to help her lift it. Grumbling the whole time. Gets back in.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: MANGOES_raw. The Vendor, after throwing the tarpaulin over the pyramid, lifting one corner to look at it once more. Letting it fall.

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: DANCER_03_raw. The Dancer between takes, sitting on the floor, shaking her head at something on her phone. Typing. Laughing out loud. Typing again. A curtain behind her moving.

Back in the room. The Protagonist is sitting very still. The laptop light on his face. The pile of untouched tapes around him.

None of this is an answer. He knows that. He sits with it anyway.

The first grey of dawn comes through the curtain gap.

69. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — MORNING

He's asleep on the floor. The laptop lid half-closed, a sliver of light still on.

The Mother looks in from the doorway on her way out. She sees him. She sees the walls. The cards. The string.

She steps in quietly. Puts a blanket over him. Turns off the laptop.

On her way out, she stops at the tap. Tightens it with both hands, hard. It holds.

She goes.

Silence. No drip.

The Protagonist sleeps.

Without the Camera

70. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — MORNING

He wakes on the floor under the blanket. Late morning light. The room very quiet. It takes him a moment to understand why: the tap isn't dripping.

He sits up. Looks at the tap. Looks at the wall of index cards. At the camcorder, on the desk, plugged in to charge. Its small light: green.

He picks it up. Holds it. Puts it down.

He pulls on a shirt and goes out.

71. EXT. CITY STREETS — DAY

The Protagonist walking. No bag. No camera. His hands in his pockets, then out of them, then in again. They don't know where to be.

We see the street as before: the tea stall's kettle steaming, two boys arguing over a bicycle, a woman hosing down a shop step, a temple bell somewhere.

He stops at the crossing. A man on a scooter, a mattress balanced across the back, wobbles past. It's funny. It's a shot. His hand goes to his chest, to where the camera used to hang. Finds nothing. He almost laughs at himself.

The light changes. He crosses.

On the other side, a boy of about six is staring up at a kite caught on a telephone wire. Just staring. The Protagonist stops beside him. Looks up too. Neither speaks. The boy's mother calls him. He goes.

The Protagonist keeps looking at the kite for a few seconds. Then walks on.

The camera, ours, stays slightly behind him, at walking pace. Not framing him. Accompanying.

72. EXT. SEAFRONT PROMENADE — AFTERNOON

The Old Couple's bench. They're there. The thermos, the crossword.

The Protagonist approaches. Sits at the far end. The Old Woman glances at him. Notices the absence of the camera. Says nothing about it.

THE OLD MAN: *(without looking up)* Six letters. "Not yet finished."

The Protagonist thinks.

THE PROTAGONIST: "Undone"?

THE OLD MAN: No. *(counting)* Yes. *(writing)* Hm.

THE OLD WOMAN: Nine down is still wrong.

THE OLD MAN: Nine down is a matter of opinion.

She pours a cup of tea. Hands it to the Protagonist without asking. He takes it.

They sit. The sea. Kites. Nobody says anything for a long time.

He's restless at first. He shifts. Looks at his phone. Puts it away. Looks at the Old Couple to see if something is happening. Nothing is happening.

Gradually, his shoulders come down a little. Only a little.

73. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — EVENING

The phone propped against a stack of tapes. A video call. THE FRIEND, on screen, in a bare rented room with a single bulb, eating noodles from a pot.

THE FRIEND (ON PHONE): It's not a lake. That's the thing. It's a reservoir. There's a fence. There's a man with a stick whose job is to stop you touching the water.

THE PROTAGONIST: Does he have a uniform?

THE FRIEND (ON PHONE): He has *half* a uniform. The top half. *(slurping)* My manager eats lunch at his desk and watches cooking videos with the sound on. Every day. A man explaining onions. I know more about onions now than I know about logistics.

The Protagonist laughs. He reaches, by habit, towards his laptop, as if to start screen-recording. His hand stops on the trackpad.

He takes it back. Puts it in his lap.

THE FRIEND (ON PHONE) (CONT'D): What? What are you doing?

THE PROTAGONIST: Nothing. *(beat)* Tell me about the onions.

THE FRIEND (ON PHONE): You want to hear about the onions?

THE PROTAGONIST: I want to hear about the onions.

The Friend looks at him through the screen, suspicious, then delighted, and launches in. The Protagonist listens. Really listens. Asks a follow-up question about shallots. The Friend has an opinion about shallots.

The call goes on. We don't need to hear all of it. We watch his face listening.

When the Friend goes quiet for a moment, a little homesick, chewing, the Protagonist doesn't fill the silence. He lets it be. After a while, the Friend says:

THE FRIEND (ON PHONE) (CONT'D): It's okay here. I think. Ask me in a month.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'll ask you in a month.

74. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — NIGHT

The soft guitar case is on top of the cupboard again, where he put it back. He takes it down. Unzips it. The snapped string, still curled.

He looks through the drawer of wires nobody knows about. Finds, impossibly, an old packet of strings, one left inside, the right gauge. He laughs once, out loud, alone.

He sits on the bed and restrings it. Badly. It takes him a long time. He has forgotten how. The new string bites his thumb, the way the Musician's did.

He tunes it by ear. Not quite right.

He plays a few notes. The beginning of something he learned at fourteen. His fingers find most of it. Then miss a chord. A dead buzz.

He stops. Laughs at himself, quietly. Starts again.

Misses it again. Laughs again.

In the doorway, unseen by him, the Mother has paused on her way to bed. She listens to three wrong attempts. Then goes, quietly. We see her face as she turns away. Something almost like a smile.

75. INT. COMMUNITY HALL — AFTERNOON

The Protagonist pushes the door an inch. Inside, the Dancer is mid-sequence. No blue tape on the floor anymore; there's a pale clean rectangle where it was peeled off.

She sees him. Glances at his hands. Empty.

THE DANCER: Ah. You found your legs.

THE PROTAGONIST: I left them at home.

THE DANCER: Good. They were ugly.

He sits on the folding chair. She goes back to work. The turn into the leap. Lands badly. Laughs. Again.

He watches. Without the screen between them, it's different. Faster. Messier. Less beautiful and more alive. He doesn't know where to look. He's used to the frame telling him.

She lands the leap. Not perfectly. Well enough. She looks over at him.

He nods. She nods. Neither says anything.

She goes back to it.

After a while, his attention drifts. He's watching the curtain. Then a pigeon on the window ledge. Then nothing. Then her again.

She catches him looking at the pigeon.

THE DANCER (CONT'D): One foot?

THE PROTAGONIST: *(surprised)* Two.

THE DANCER: Disappointing.

76. INT. MUSICIAN'S ROOM — NIGHT

The bar, playing from the top of the stairs. The Protagonist climbs. Knocks.

THE MUSICIAN (O.S.): It doesn't close.

He goes in. The Musician sees his empty hands. Keeps playing.

The Protagonist sits on the plastic chair. The fan clicks.

The Musician plays the bar. Slips. Plays it again. Slips. Plays it a third time.

It doesn't slip.

He stops. Stares at his left hand like it belongs to someone else.

THE MUSICIAN: Did you hear that?

THE PROTAGONIST: I heard it.

THE MUSICIAN: Nine years.

He plays it again immediately. Slips.

They both burst out laughing.

THE MUSICIAN (CONT'D): *(wiping his eyes)* That's fine. That's fine. It exists now. I know it exists.

He hands the Protagonist a paper cup of tea from the flask. Picks up the guitar. Starts playing the melody, the nameless one. It's different tonight. Slower in one place, a turn somewhere new.

The Protagonist listens. He doesn't reach for anything. His hand is around the warm cup.

When it ends, he doesn't say "did I get it." He doesn't say anything. He sips the tea.

The Musician tunes a string. Hums.

77. EXT. LANE OUTSIDE PAINTER'S HOUSE — LATE MORNING

The Protagonist walks down the lane. No bags. In one hand, a small paper parcel tied with string.

He stops at the blue door with the green beneath. Stands there. Doesn't knock for a while.

Knocks.

Footsteps. The door opens. The Painter. He looks at the Protagonist. At his hands. At the parcel.

THE PAINTER: It's Thursday.

THE PROTAGONIST: I know.

The Painter turns and goes inside. Leaves the door open.

78. INT. PAINTER'S STUDIO — CONTINUOUS

The studio exactly as before. The Painter goes back to the easel. The sea painting. The patch of blue.

The Protagonist puts the parcel on the table by the kettle.

THE PAINTER: What's that?

THE PROTAGONIST: Biscuits. The ones with the jam in the middle.

THE PAINTER: I don't like those.

THE PROTAGONIST: You ate six last time.

THE PAINTER: I was being polite.

He unwraps the parcel. Takes one. Eats it while studying the canvas.

The Protagonist sits on the crate. The light stand is gone; the crate is just a crate again.

Silence. The papaya tree. The radio, low. A man on the news talking about a water shortage.

THE PAINTER (CONT'D): The cobalt's gone up again. Did you know that? Forty per cent. In one year. For a tube the size of my finger.

THE PROTAGONIST: Why?

THE PAINTER: Because the world is run by thieves. *(beat)* Also something about mines. I read it. I've forgotten.

He dips a brush. Stops. Looks at the brush. The bristles are splayed, one clump bent sideways.

THE PAINTER (CONT'D): Look at this. Look what it's done.

THE PROTAGONIST: Can it be fixed?

THE PAINTER: Hot water. Soap. And then you shape it and leave it. Overnight. Wrapped in paper. Like a baby.

THE PROTAGONIST: I'll do it.

The Painter hands him the brush without a word.

79. INT. PAINTER'S STUDIO — LATER

The Protagonist at the small sink in the corner, washing the brush with care. Working soap into the bristles. Rinsing. Shaping the tip between his fingers. Wrapping it in a strip of newspaper.

The Painter at the easel, working, his back to him.

Neither of them speaks. It isn't awkward. It isn't quite comfortable either. It's just the afternoon.

The Protagonist finishes with the brush. Sets it on the windowsill to dry. Sits back down on the crate.

Nothing to do now.

He sits. His knee jiggles. He stops it. He looks at the canvases with their faces to the wall. He looks at the photograph of the woman laughing in the doorway.

He doesn't ask who she is.

THE PAINTER: *(not turning)* It's going to rain at four.

THE PROTAGONIST: How do you know?

THE PAINTER: My knee. And the radio.

80. INT. PAINTER'S STUDIO — FOUR O'CLOCK

Rain. As promised. Heavy on the courtyard, loud on the tin above the back door.

The two of them sitting, the Painter in the cane chair, the Protagonist on the crate, drinking tea, watching it come down through the open back door. The papaya tree bowing under it.

The Painter's sea painting on the easel between them. We see the patch of blue more closely now. It is almost something. Not finished. Almost.

They don't talk about it.

They watch the rain.

After a long time:

THE PAINTER: You'll stay till it stops. You'll get wet otherwise and then your mother will blame me.

THE PROTAGONIST: She doesn't know you.

THE PAINTER: Mothers find out.

The Protagonist smiles. Drinks his tea. Watches the rain.

The tea goes cold in his hand while he watches. When he notices, he drinks it anyway. All of it.

The Painter sees. Grunts. Satisfied.

The Honest Cut

81. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — DAY

The curtains open. Daylight. Ordinary, unflattering daylight.

The Protagonist is taking the index cards off the wall. One by one. ARTISAN. DEVOTION. LOSS. PRESENCE. He doesn't throw them away. He stacks them, squares the edges, puts a rubber band around them, and puts them in the drawer of wires nobody knows about.

The string he winds around two fingers into a small loop. Puts it in the drawer too.

The wall is bare again. Tiny pin holes in the faded paint. The nail with nothing on it.

He opens the laptop.

82. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — DAY — CONTINUOUS

ON LAPTOP SCREEN: The polished timeline. The music track sits beneath everything like a floor.

He selects the music track. Holds the cursor over it.

Deletes it.

He plays the cut. Without the music, the room tone comes up. The scrape of the palette knife. The fan. The flower market. Traffic. The film suddenly sounds like the world, and everything in it looks a little more ordinary and a little more real.

He leaves it like that.

83. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — DAYS — A SERIES OF MOMENTS

The work. Not a montage of triumph. Slow, plain, sometimes boring. We see it in pieces.

- He removes the Painter's mimed brushstroke, the perfect one an inch from the canvas. In its place, he puts back the raw shot: the Painter's hand drifting to the photograph of the woman in the doorway, straightening it, returning to the brushes. He doesn't add a caption. He doesn't explain who she is. He doesn't know.
- He replaces the Musician's clean melody with the first version, the one where the frame slipped. Tilted, half a face, a slice of fan. He lets it play all the way through.

- He removes the Dancer landing on the blue X. He finds the earliest leap, the one she landed by accident and whispered "Don't say anything." Her face is in shadow. He leaves it in shadow.
- He extends the Old Couple's shot past the point he'd cut. The Old Woman's hand on her husband's chest. Eleven seconds. He counts them with his lips. He leaves all eleven.
- He finds the Bus Driver grumbling while lifting the woman's rice sack, and keeps the grumbling.
- He finds the night bus footage: the empty seat in front, recorded while he was putting the little girl's shoe back on. Twenty seconds of a vibrating plastic seat under a tube light. In the soundtrack, faintly, the father's murmured thanks. He looks at it for a long time. He keeps it.
- He puts back the shot of the Vendor lifting the corner of the tarpaulin to look at his pyramid one more time.
- He keeps the Musician's laughing mistake. The shaking camera. His own laughter. He doesn't turn his laughter down.

Each change is small. Some of them he undoes and then redoes. At one point he puts a piece of music back under a scene, listens, and takes it out again with a small sigh, not of failure, of recognition.

84. INT. PROTAGONIST'S FLAT — KITCHEN — NIGHT

The Mother at the table, shelling peas into a steel plate. The Protagonist comes in with the laptop, hesitates, and sits beside her.

THE PROTAGONIST: Do you want to see some?

She looks at him. Wipes her hands on her sari.

THE MOTHER: Some.

He plays it. We don't see the screen. We see her face, lit by it. She watches with the same expression she wears when watching television serials she claims to dislike. Attentive. Faintly critical.

The sound: the flower market. The fan. A guitar. A woman laughing at her own leap.

THE MOTHER (CONT'D): *(after a while)* That girl should put ice on that knee.

THE PROTAGONIST: She does. Sometimes.

THE MOTHER: Sometimes isn't ice.

She keeps watching. Shells a pea without looking. Then another.

The Old Couple on the bench. The wind. The eleven seconds.

The Mother stops shelling. Her hands rest on the plate.

She says nothing. When the shot ends, she goes back to the peas.

THE MOTHER (CONT'D): Does it end?

THE PROTAGONIST: Not yet.

THE MOTHER: Hm.

She pushes the plate towards him. He starts shelling too. The laptop plays on beside them. Neither of them looks at it the whole time.

85. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — NIGHT

Late. He's sitting at the desk. The last tape is beside the laptop: the one from the camera the Dancer returned. He hasn't watched it.

Label, in his marker, written weeks ago: DANCER 8.

He slides it into the camcorder. Connects the cable. Presses play.

86. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — CONTINUOUS — ON LAPTOP SCREEN

DANCER 8 (CAMCORDER FOOTAGE): The hall. The tripod's view: the long wooden floor, the tall windows, the stacked chairs at the edge.

At the very beginning, the back of the Protagonist's shirt crosses the frame, walking out. The side door bangs, softly.

Then: nothing.

The empty hall.

We watch it full-screen. Not as the small grainy insert, but filling the film's own frame, so for a while the audience forgets which camera they're looking through.

Sunlight slowly shifts across the wooden floor. A slab of gold widening by degrees.

A curtain moves slightly in the breeze. Settles. Moves again.

From the verandah, faint and wordless, two voices. A laugh, hers. Then they fade, as though the speakers have turned away.

A pigeon lands on the outside ledge of one window, a dark shape against the light. Takes off.

The frame is slightly tilted. Not much. Enough to notice.

Somewhere outside, a pressure cooker whistles. A long way off, a bus changes gear.

A shadow crosses the doorway at the far end of the hall: someone walking past in the corridor. It's there for less than a second. Then it's gone.

The light keeps moving. The gold reaches the faded rectangle where the blue tape X used to be, and passes over it, and keeps going.

This lasts almost a minute. Nothing happens. Everything happens.

87. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — CONTINUOUS

Back in the room. The Protagonist is watching. His face is lit by the screen.

We hold on him.

There is no revelation in his face. No tears. No smile. Only stillness, and a kind of willingness. He is letting it be what it is.

The footage runs on. He doesn't skip. He doesn't scrub. He doesn't take notes.

On the screen, the tape runs out. The image breaks into grey static. Then blue.

He sits with the blue screen for a moment.

Then he imports the clip into his timeline. Drags it to the very end. Trims nothing from it. Not the shirt at the start, not the static at the end.

He plays the last five minutes of his film, start to finish. We don't see them. We hear them. Room tone, wind, a guitar, a bus, laughter, a curtain, a long empty hall.

The blue screen.

He exports it. A progress bar crawls across the screen. He watches the progress bar, then stops watching it, and looks out the window instead. The neighbour's kitchen across the gap is dark. A single cup stands upside down on the drying rack, catching the streetlight.

The export finishes with a small chime.

He closes the laptop.

The room is dark. Quiet.

He lies down on the bed, fully dressed, shoes on, the way we first saw him. But his eyes close. He sleeps.

The Sea

88. INT. PROTAGONIST'S BEDROOM — MORNING

He wakes. Sits up. Takes his shoes off, finally, and puts them side by side by the bed. Then, realising he's going out, puts them back on.

The camcorder sits on the desk next to the closed laptop. The little hand-drawn flower sticker. The knotted strap.

He looks at it. Not with resentment. Not with longing. The way you look at a friend's coat left on a chair.

He leaves it there.

89. INT. PROTAGONIST'S FLAT — KITCHEN — CONTINUOUS

The Mother is drinking tea standing up, already late. She sees him dressed, his hands empty.

THE MOTHER: Where are you going?

THE PROTAGONIST: Out.

THE MOTHER: Out where?

THE PROTAGONIST: I don't know yet.

She looks at him. Then nods, as if that's a perfectly reasonable answer. She hands him the half-cup of tea she was drinking. He finishes it. She takes the empty cup back and goes.

90. EXT. CITY — DAY — SERIES OF SHOTS

He walks. Our camera keeps a respectful distance. Sometimes in front of him, sometimes behind, never too close.

- The flower market lane. The Florist, mid-argument with the marigold man about a price. She sees the Protagonist pass. Gives him the smallest nod. Goes back to arguing.
- The market road. Above the hardware shop, the window open. A guitar, faintly: the bar. It slips. Starts again. The Protagonist doesn't stop. He smiles slightly as he walks under it.
- A bus stop. A bus pulls in. Through the windscreen, the Bus Driver, towel on his shoulder. Destination board: LIGHTHOUSE.

91. INT. CITY BUS (MOVING) — AFTERNOON

The Protagonist sits by a window. We are inside with him now, not outside looking in through glass.

The city goes by. He watches it. Not the reflections. The street itself.

At one stop, a young man with a moustache gets on, office bag, lanyard. He nods at the Driver. The Driver nods back.

The Protagonist notices. Says nothing.

The bus empties stop by stop until it's only him and two schoolgirls sharing earphones.

Last stop. The Driver kills the engine, stretches, wipes his face with the towel. He glances at the Protagonist in the big mirror.

THE BUS DRIVER: Last stop. This is where it ends.

THE PROTAGONIST: Then what?

THE BUS DRIVER: Then it goes back. *(he shrugs)* Twenty minutes. Tea first.

The Protagonist gets off.

92. EXT. SEASHORE NEAR THE LIGHTHOUSE — LATE AFTERNOON

A wide, open beach. The old lighthouse at one end, its paint peeling. Fishing boats pulled up on the sand. The sea vast and grey-green, turning gold at the edges.

Ordinary life. Children chasing a ball into the shallows and running back screaming when the waves follow. A family packing up a picnic, a grandmother refusing help folding a mat. A corn seller fanning coals. Dogs. Two teenagers sitting a careful distance apart, pretending they aren't together.

The Protagonist walks down onto the sand. Finds a spot. Sits.

He looks at the sea.

93. EXT. SEASHORE — CONTINUOUS — THE LIGHT

The sun lowering. The light beginning to move across the water. A long gold path on the waves.

The Protagonist watches it.

After a minute, he shifts. His hand moves towards his pocket. His phone. He touches it through the cloth.

He doesn't take it out.

Nearby, a YOUNG WOMAN stands at the edge of the water with her phone held up at the sky. She takes a photo. Looks at it. Frowns. Takes another. Steps back. Tries again. Crouches. Holds the phone higher. The sky is enormous, orange and violet; the photo, every time, is a small dull rectangle. She sighs. Tries again.

The Protagonist watches her trying. Something like recognition. Something like tenderness. No judgement.

She gives up, finally. Lowers the phone. And stands there, just looking at the sky with her own eyes, arms at her sides.

The Protagonist looks back at the sea.

94. EXT. SEASHORE — CONTINUOUS — LATER

The light fades by degrees.

We hold on the Protagonist for a long time. He watches the gold go copper, go rose, go grey. The wind lifts his hair and drops it. The waves come in and pull out. Children are called home. The corn seller's coals glow brighter as the sky dims.

At one point his knee starts to jiggle. He notices. Lets it. Then it stops by itself.

At one point his face clouds; some old feeling passes through him, and we don't know what. It passes. Or doesn't. He stays.

He doesn't reach for a camera. Or a phone. Or a notebook. He doesn't try to keep it.

The last of the light leaves the water. The sea is dark. The lighthouse beam comes on, sweeps once over the beach, over him, and moves on.

He stays a little longer.

Then he stands, brushes the sand off his trousers, and walks back up the beach towards the road. Towards home.

The camera does not follow him.

We stay where he was sitting. The dent in the sand. The dark sea. The lighthouse beam going round. The young woman, still standing at the water's edge. Someone's forgotten sandal.

95. EXT. A STREET IN THE CITY — EARLY MORNING

A wide, static shot. An ordinary street. We have perhaps seen it in passing, perhaps not.

An old wall, its plaster stained in the shapes of years of monsoons. The first sunlight comes across it and rests there, a pale gold rectangle on the old paint.

A shopkeeper rolls up a shutter. It clatters. He begins to sweep the pavement in front of his shop with a long broom. Slow strokes.

Two schoolchildren cross the street, holding hands, one dragging a bag on wheels that bounces on every stone.

A bus pulls in at the corner, waits, and pulls away. We don't see who got on.

The leaves of a peepal tree at the edge of the frame shift in a breeze. Then still. Then shift.

A dog crosses, stops in the middle of the road, scratches, considers, and continues.

A woman on a balcony shakes out a bedsheet. It billows, white, then falls.

No music. Only the sounds of the morning: the broom, birds, a distant pressure horn, a radio somewhere, a kettle, voices too far away to understand.

The Protagonist is not in this shot. He does not walk into it.

We hold. And hold. Long enough that the audience starts to wait for something to happen. Longer than that. Long enough that the waiting itself becomes noticeable, and then, perhaps, falls away.

The light on the old wall moves, very slightly.

The shopkeeper finishes sweeping. Leans the broom against the wall. Stands for a moment in the doorway of his shop, looking at the street. Then goes inside.

The street continues.

CUT TO BLACK.

In the black, the sounds of the street continue for a few seconds. Then they too fade.

Silence.

TITLE: **EVERYTHING WAS ALREADY ALIVE**

THE END